1934 when he was conferred a knighthood and the bank suffering no ill-effects of the episode went on to celebrate its silver jubilee in 1936. As Karanjia writes, ‘The ugly unfortunate incident was forgotten and only the good Pochkhanawala did lived after him.’[24] The bank clerk had arrived and it must have been with pardonable pride that Sir Sorabji asked his wife, ‘Well, Lady Sakerbai, how do you feel about this?’ Sorabji got the news of his being knighted when he was in Colombo, and had a hard time convincing his guests whom he had invited for lunch that he had had no inkling about the honour recently bestowed on him.

A Lamp is Extinguished

By 1935–36, the Central Bank had become the largest bank in India with deposits totaling ₹25 crore, which were equal to approximately one-third of the total deposits in all the other eighty-four banks. The Central Bank was now nationally recognized as a swadeshi bank which had given the lie to the belief that Indians were incapable of being good bankers. Its performance had silenced its critics: it had not only survived, but flourished, and laid the foundations of modern Indian banking apart from being a source of talent and inspiration for the banking system.

At the time of the bank’s silver jubilee, the paid-up capital and reserves stood at ₹2.5 crores and deposits at ₹31 crores. The bank had eighty-four branches, and the tributes which came pouring in, praised the financial rectitude of the bank and its judicious blending of policies to reconcile the two seemingly opposed forces of conservatism and progressiveness. A message from Sorabji on the occasion summed up his philosophy of banking and the Central Bank’s role in it. He said that the benefits of a good bank were not restricted to the four walls of its banking hall, nor were they limited by the frontiers of its banking business—they transcended far into the realms of commerce and industry and every other branch of economic activity. Sorabji said that the Central regarded itself as the ‘People’s Own Bank’ and hoped that through the cooperation and patronage of the people it would continue to grow not only in size, but also in the extent and quality of its services to the country.[25]

But Sorabji was not one to rest on his laurels. Yet another first, this time not only for the Central Bank, but for Indian banking, was the establishment